

TATA unveils plans to provide 100Mbps Internet connections

Seagate's first hard drive was the 5 MB ST-506 released in 1980

sense if you're looking at performance and don't have to move large amount of data around. Although it's not a very large capacity drive, it performs almost as good as any other new WD drive in this test, but at a fraction of the cost. If you are still chasing performance, then the top performer in this section is the WD My Passport Elite 500 GB, but just by a marginal difference.

External desktop hard drives

For those who need to periodically backup huge amounts of data, a portable solution just won't do. The capacities are too small and the performance simply isn't there. An external storage solution through its abundance of configurations and sizes is sure to serve such a user.

The Western Digital My Book Mirror Edition comes with two 1 TB hard drives in a RAID configuration. Data is replicated on drives, so if a drive fails you always have a backup. The only downside is that you get to use only 1 TB. With an MRP of Rs. 31,500, it's also very expensive. The other problem with two big drives in a single chassis is the weight. We didn't really like the quality of the large-sized Western Digital drives: their outer shell was a little thin and did not inspire the confidence to be carried around.

Just like we did with the portable drives, we ran benchmarks using Firewire and USB. eSATA was the other connectivity option available in this category. While a Firewire port made a difference in most of the benchmarks, eSATA really opened the floodgates.

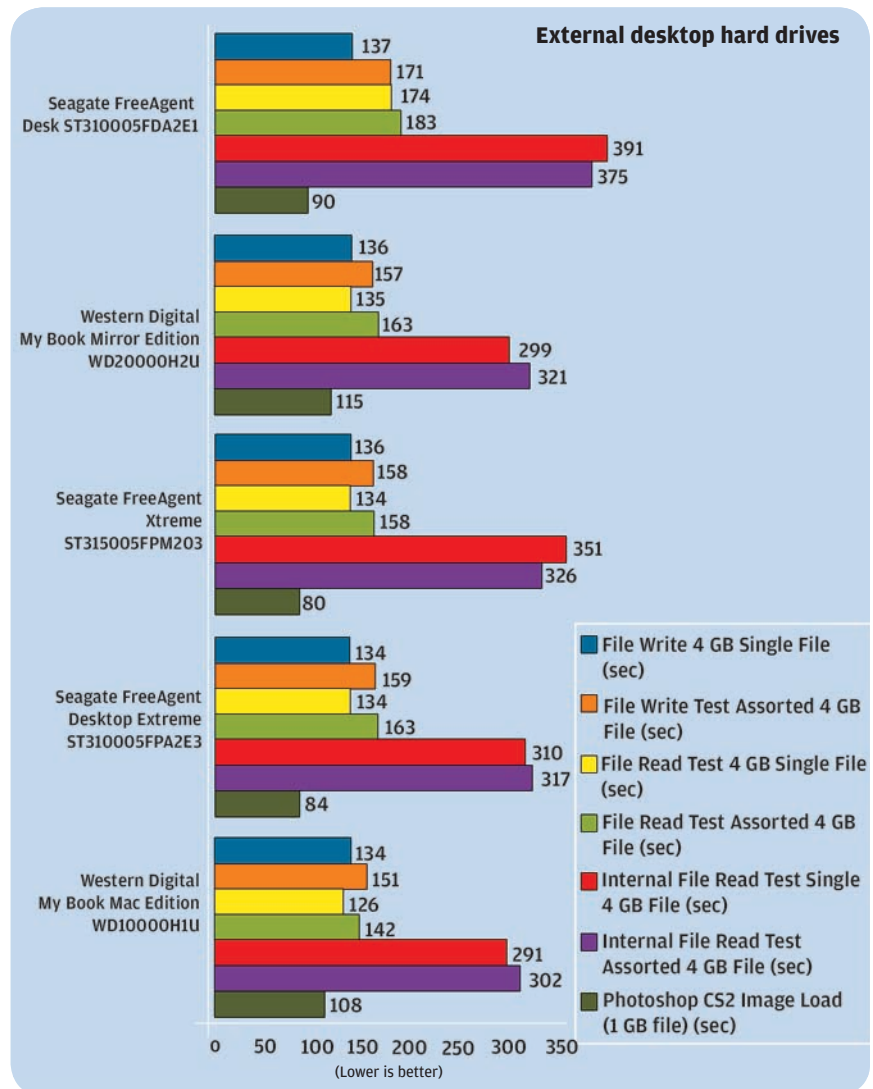
All the drives performed exceptionally well, but the Western Digital My Book Studio Edition II 2 TB drive flew through the majority of the tests.

The Xtreme series from Seagate came with eSATA and Firewire features, but if capacity is your prime concern, the 1TB FreeAgent Desk is the one you need. Its price also makes excellent value for money.

We found that the fastest USB drive was the 1-TB Western Digital My Book Mac Edition. Again, the limitation was the bandwidth provided by USB and most of the USB drives ranked close to each other.

We can conclude through this test that with rising capacities, there's an equal improvement in performance. Today, not everybody buys a drive for its performance and even if they do, one is mainly to store movies and games. For that kind of user, a power-efficient smart drive is required. Internet connection speeds have shot up and there can never be enough space. To give you an idea of how far drives have progressed, if this was the late 90s, an entire disk would be easily exhausted in a day. ■

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Decision maker	
Internal drives	
Best 1 Terabyte drive	Seagate Barracuda 7200.12 1 TB
Best 2 Terabyte drive	WD Caviar Green 2 TB
Best 750 GB drive	Seagate Barracuda 7200.11 750GB
Best performer under Rs. 4,000	Western Digital Caviar WD3200AAKS or Seagate Barracuda 7200.11 500 GB
Portable Drives	
Best 500 GB performer	Western Digital My Passport Elite 500 GB
Best Value for money	Western Digital My Passport Studio 250 GB
External Desktop Drives	
Fastest drive (eSATA)	Western Digital My Book Studio Edition II 2 TB
Fastest drive (USB)	Western Digital My Book Studio Edition II 2 TB
Secure data storage	Western Digital My Book Mirror Edition

Contact Sheet				
Hard Drive Comparison Test				
Brand	Contact	Phone	E-mail address	Web-site
Hitachi	Cyberstar Infocom Pvt Ltd	+91-99725 80114	lalit.sudrik@cyberstarindia.com	www.hitachigst.com
Iomega	Iomega Corporation	+91-98410 22940	baskaran@iomega.com	www.iomega.com
Seagate	Fortune Marketing	+91-11-2641 4468	sales@fortune-it.com	www.seagate.com
Western Digital	Amarjeet Singh	+91-93210 29204	amarjeet.singh@wdc.com	www.wdc.com